

3, The Chinese Rulers Were Crystal Clear About the Military Superiority of the Feudal System

The third aspect: the conclusion that the feudal system is militarily superior to the **restoration-bureaucratic system** is fundamentally not a realization exclusive to modern people. The fact is, during the **restoration-bureaucratic period**, even despotic monarchs (专制君主) and high-ranking bureaucrats had no choice but to admit this.

If we direct our attention to some of the most crucial historical documents from the transition between the Northern and Southern Song Dynasties—namely, the *Compiled Documents on the Treaties with the North during Three Reigns* (《三朝北盟会编》) and the *Chronological Record of the Reign Since Jianyan* (《建炎以来系年要录》)—it is not difficult to discover contemporaneous acknowledgments of the pronounced superiority of **feudalized** frontier warlords (藩镇) when facing the pressure of newly emerging ethnic minority regimes.

Below, I list a few historical fragments whose contents are exceptionally fascinating. One can easily discern from them just how crystal clear an understanding China's rulers and high intellectuals still possessed regarding the "success or failure of the realm" (天下成败) even as late as the early 12th century.

The first record is a memorial submitted by the Censor-in-Chief (御史中丞) Qin Hui (秦桧) to the Supreme Marshal's Office of the Jin Dynasty right after the Jingkang Incident (靖康之变) occurred (the second month of the second year of Jingkang). This is found in Volume 2 of *The Record* (《要录》) and Volume 80 of *The Compilation* (《会编》), which contains the following passage:

"Ever since the Great Jin dispatched its armies to condemn the **Zhongyuan** last year, over a year has passed in border incursions and battles. (大金自去岁问罪中原，入境征战已逾岁矣。) However, the reason you conquer whatever you attack is nothing else but the fact that the Great Jin has long been accustomed to warfare, whereas China has enjoyed a century of peace; our soldiers are scarcely trained, and we have not found the right men to serve as generals and commanders. (然所攻必克者无他，以大金久习兵革，中国承平百年，士卒罕练将帅未得其人也。) Since ancient times, the might of China's territory and armored troops has been unmatched by any neighbor, and the world has never lacked talented heroes to serve as generals and ministers. (自古中国地土甲兵之威四邻无有，将相英雄世不乏才。) If, in the future, our soldiers become highly trained like the troops of the Tang Dynasty's frontier warlords, and we obtain the right men as generals and ministers like the loyal subjects of Emperors Daizong and Suzong of Tang —(使异日士卒精练，若唐藩镇之兵，将相得人，若唐代肃之臣。) Could the Great Jin still be absolutely certain of its victory over China?!" (大金之於中国能必其胜哉！)

The core purpose of Qin Hui's admonition to the Jin rulers lay in two points: do not annihilate the Song (*to establish Zhang Bangchang*), and do not massacre the Zhao imperial clan of Song. As the stance of a minister of a subjugated nation, this was entirely normal.

What truly imbues this document with profound "historical significance" is the astonishing argument Qin Hui presented. After initially emphasizing that the Zhao Song's Mandate of Heaven had not yet been extinguished, he highly cryptically pointed out where the critical crux of interests lay:

"The reason you Jin people were able to drive deep and achieve such massive battle results is not because you are invincibly strong, but because the Song Dynasty itself is extremely debilitated. (你

们金人之所以能够长驱直入取得如此之大的战果，并非因为你们强到不可战胜，而是宋朝本身极度衰弱所致。)

—(*Since the Five Dynasties, the Song Dynasty, in order to suppress all possible domestic uncertainties, established an unprecedentedly massive bureaucratic system. The emperor prioritized his own interests above those of the state, fearing his own army and generals more than he feared foreign armies and generals.*) (自五代之后，宋朝建立为了压制国内一切可能的不确定因素建立了空前庞大的官僚体制，皇帝视自己的利益高过了国家的利益，担心自己的军队和将领超过了担心异族的军队和将领)

Therefore, the armed forces of the entire nation collapse at the first blow. (因此整个国家的武装力量不堪一击。)

—(*If today the Jin Dynasty insists on exterminating the Zhao clan, it would ironically be ridding the realm of an autocrat.*) (今天金朝如果非要尽诛赵氏，那么反而为天下除去一个独夫)

Feudalized frontier warlords like those of the Tang Dynasty would then spring up one after another. (像唐代那样的封建化藩镇就会接踵而起。)

Relying on China's demographic and economic scale, at that time, do you Jin people truly believe you could still fight and win? (凭借中国的人口和经济规模，到那个时候你们金人自忖还能战而胜之吗？)

It is better to preserve the state altars of the Song and still let the Zhao clan rule as despotic monarchs. —(This way, the Zhao imperial house, for the private interests of their single family, will first and foremost remain vigilant against their own generals and commoners, thereby eliminating this genuine danger on behalf of the Jin people.)— This is beneficial to both you Jin rulers and the Zhao Song imperial family. (不如保留宋朝的社稷，仍然让赵氏做专制君主，（这样赵宋官家为了一姓私利首先警惕自己的将领和百姓，替金人消弭了这一真正的危险）对于你们金朝统治者也好，赵宋皇室也罢都是有利的。)

This memorial by Qin Hui fully reflects his astonishing foresight as a quintessential "bureaucratic politician" (官僚主义政治家) unique to China. Even right after the Jingkang Incident occurred, he already possessed a crystal-clear understanding of the situation of the realm and the demands of all parties' interests.

Qin Hui clearly realized that, in responding to historical events like the Jin invasion, **feudalized** frontier warlords possessed an incomparable superiority over the Song Dynasty's bureaucratic system.

However, out of historical memories of the fragmented late Tang and Five Dynasties, and the absolute need to maintain despotic rule, the despotic monarchs of the Song Empire inevitably felt as if sitting on a bed of nails (如坐针毡) regarding these threats sleeping right beside their beds. Once the Song Dynasty could achieve basic parity with the Jin Dynasty, the emperor's fear of the frontier warlords would blatantly surpass his fear of foreign barbarians who could be placated with land, wealth, and people.

Therefore, at the very beginning of the Jingkang Incident, Qin Hui astutely pointed out that, in the long run, negotiating a peace treaty was mutually beneficial to the rulers of both nations.

However, the rapidly rising Jin people could not possibly comprehend Chinese politics so quickly, nor could they slam the brakes on their chariot of conquest so fast. In order to force the Jin people back to the negotiating table, the Southern Song had no choice but to emulate the Tang frontier warlords, utilizing military commanders who were **feudalized** to a certain degree to achieve military parity by force and realize a peace treaty as quickly as possible.

Once this was done, they could concentrate all their energy on using both hard and soft tactics to snatch back the military power of these generals. As for those among them who possessed considerable battle merit and prestige but were not entirely submissive, they could be executed even on "groundless" (莫须有 / *Moxuyou*) charges.

The historical tableau unfurled across the Chinese land during the transition between the two Song dynasties paints a crystal-clear picture for posterity of the extreme reactionary nature (极端反动性) of the **restoration-bureaucratic state**, as well as the sheer subjectivity of its implementation of reactionary policies.

The second record is a memorial submitted to Zhao Gou (Emperor Gaozong of Song) by the then-Chancellor (宰相) Li Gang (李纲) on the 2nd day of the 6th month of the first year of Jianyan (*the same year as the second year of Jingkang, i.e., 1127 AD*), barely a month after Zhao Gou ascended the throne. This is found in Volume 6 of *The Record* (《要录》) and Volume 105 of *The Compilation* (《会编》).

The meaning of this memorial was exceptionally blunt: to resolutely and publicly abandon peace negotiations, unequivocally continue the war against the Jin Dynasty, first strengthen defenses, and subsequently plot for revenge. All state affairs at present should revolve around the war against Jin. In this memorial, Li Gang explicitly pointed out that frontier warlords (藩镇) were extremely useful and necessary at this moment.

"For today's strategy, there is nothing better than halting all peace negotiations and focusing entirely on the tactic of self-defense. Establish frontier warlord commands (藩镇) in strategic strongholds, and position marshal headquarters south of the Yellow River and the Jiang-Huai region. (为今之计, 莫若一切罢和议, 専务自守之策, 建藩镇于要害之地, 置帅府于大河及江淮之南,) Repair the city walls, prepare weapons and siege engines, train the naval forces, and practice chariot warfare. (修城壁, 治器械, 教水军, 习车战,) Ensure that if the enemy advances, they gain nothing from plundering, and if they retreat, they suffer the peril of being intercepted. Thus, although they may appear and vanish, they will absolutely not dare to drive deep. (使其进无抄掠之得, 退有邀击之患, 则虽有出没, 必不敢深入,) Within three to five years, military administration will be increasingly perfected, and armored troops and chariots will be fully prepared. Only then should we launch a massive campaign to subjugate them, to avenge the unshareable heaven of our enmity, and to wash away an unprecedented humiliation since antiquity! (三数年间, 军政益修, 甲车咸备, 然后大举以讨之, 报不共戴天之仇, 雪振古所无之耻,) Once the enemy knows China has strengthened itself to such a degree, not only will they not dare to act tyrannically, but there will also be a reasonable path to safely securing the Two Sage Emperors (Huizong and Qinzong)!" (彼知中国自强如此, 岂徒不敢肆横, 而二圣有可安之理矣!)

In this exposition, one can clearly see that Li Gang possessed considerable cognitive understanding of the military function of the frontier warlords. He specifically pointed out that they could construct massive numbers of feudal castles and independently arm their troops.

Once the Jin army launched an offensive, the commoners near the castles could withdraw into them, and materials could be transferred and protected (*this is essentially identical to the Middle Ages in Europe*). It would be incredibly difficult for the Jin army to conquer such castles, so even if they advanced, they would struggle to plunder many resources. But if the Jin army wanted to retreat easily, they would have to find ways to avoid pursuit by the armies within the castles. Thus, while the Jin army would still appear on the borders, it would be very difficult for them to drive deep.

This understanding very likely reflects how the Jin army's southern invasion awakened people's historical memories of the fortified manors (坞堡) extensively constructed by powerful Han Chinese clans in the North during the Sixteen Kingdoms period.

Emperor Gaozong's reaction to this memorial was: "*The Emperor was greatly pleased, and handed it to the Secretariat to be observed and implemented.*" From this, it is evident that even Zhao Gou himself harbored no objections to Li Gang's proposal.

The third document is a suggestion presented by Xie Kejia (谢克家), the Minister of War (兵部尚书), in the 8th month of the third year of Jianyan, found in Volume 27 of *The Record* (《要录》). His words were exceedingly brief, yet virtually every sentence struck the vital core. This proposal by Xie Kejia can absolutely be hailed as the highest standard of Chinese political discourse from the Sui and Tang Dynasties to the present.

"Xie Kejia, the Minister of War, stated: Today, there is an excess of redundant officials, especially in the outer provinces. I request that they all be dismissed to relieve the burden on the people's strength. (兵部尚书谢克家言, 今日冗官, 外方尤甚, 请悉罢之, 以纾民力。) He also stated: The imperial army is weak and scarce, whereas the commanderies and counties all possess powerful local elites. We ought to order them to mutually elect leaders among themselves; those with wisdom and valor should each defend their own lands. Wherever commanderies and counties lack officials, I beg to permit the prefects to appoint them personally. (又言: '官军单寡, 而郡县皆有土豪, 宜令自相推择, 有智勇者各守其地, 郡县有阙官处, 乞许郡守自辟。) Provided there are no obstructions in the bureaucratic selection process, grant them official commissions. If they show favoritism or corruption, the supervising commissioners and censors can impeach them. (吏铨无碍, 则付以告身。若其徇私, 则监司、御史得以纠之。) Today, the Jingdong, Jingxi, and Jiang-Huai regions have all been reduced to wilderness and overgrown thickets; it is difficult to apply normal laws. We should establish frontier warlords (藩镇), conferring both civil and military authority, allowing them to act expediently according to circumstances, and permitting them to utilize financial revenues as they see fit. (今京东、西及江、淮悉为榛莽, 难用常法, 宜建藩镇, 文武并授, 令得便宜从事, 财赋亦听自用。) If they achieve merit in defending against the enemy, permit them hereditary succession.'" (如捍御有功, 则许世袭'。)

Astonishingly, five viewpoints are expressed within these mere four lines: **First**, although the phenomenon of redundant officials (冗官) in the Song Empire was itself a means of maintaining despotic imperial power and consolidating the restoration-bureaucratic system, implementing it now, when Jin troops were ravaging China and the Zhao Song imperial throne was already unstable, was utterly absurd. Particularly in the localities, the bloated bureaucracy fundamentally lacked

effective response capabilities while pointlessly draining local financial resources; it was entirely insufficient to cope with military threats. He suggested they should be thoroughly dismissed, and the commoners should be spared further torment. **Second**, the locally powerful landlord class could serve as the mainstay in bearing military obligations to resist the Jin troops. Under the current circumstances, they should be heavily relied upon. Forget about whether it conformed to bureaucratic procedures; first bestow upon them the righteous titles and status. **Third**, although Emperor Taizong, Zhao Guangyi, was utterly determined to centralize the power of appointing and dismissing all officials nationwide, dealing with the Jin people was now the paramount task. The court should cease playing those tricks of mutual checks and balances that only dragged down everyone's legs. For now, it was best to decentralize personnel power to boost local enthusiasm and enhance their operational capacity. Officials recommended locally should be almost directly acknowledged; even if problems arose, having censors issue an impeachment or warning would suffice. **Fourth**, the thousands of kilometers of war zone between Song and Jin were currently in sheer chaos, with local heroes and warlords rising simultaneously. Talking about rebuilding the bureaucratic system was pure nonsense. We must urgently establish frontier warlords to win over those local armed forces, integrating both civil officials and military generals into the framework of the *Fanzhen* (frontier warlords), expanding their power to make independent decisions. Simultaneously, cease collecting taxes from the warlords, allowing them to substitute taxes with military obligations. **Fifth**, as long as these frontier warlords achieved merit in resisting the Jin army, the court must not scheme to replace them with circulating officials (*Liuguan* / 流官); instead, directly permit them hereditary succession (世袭) and bestow upon them the titles of kings and dukes.

Therefore, one can distinctly sense from Xie Kejia's words that, even though the Chinese Empire had already entered the **restoration-bureaucratic period**, up until the transition between the two Song dynasties, intellectuals still possessed a profound understanding of **feudalization**. They were acutely aware of what characteristics a **feudal society** was supposed to have, and in their hearts, they understood perfectly well how massive the superiority of the **feudal system** was over the **restoration-bureaucratic system**.

However, mutually interdependent monarchical despotism and the bureaucratic system had become so entrenched. Facing a massive threat like the Jin army's southern invasion, the court might temporarily permit some **feudalized** elements to reappear; but once the threat dissipated, the state inevitably reverted to its old path leading toward Doomsday.

Actually, anyone with sense can realize exactly *who* such a perverse bureaucratic system was primarily designed to target—it was never a secret.

For instance, during the most grueling period of Nazi Germany's invasion in 1942, the Soviet Union abolished the final decision-making power of the political commissars. From then on, the power of political cadres in the army was restricted and increasingly weakened.

Cunning and treacherous bureaucratic rulers never forget that their bayonets are pointed at their own people, not for the purpose of resisting some foreign invader. Once the external threat becomes too overwhelming, they themselves will dismantle aspects of the bureaucratic system to unleash the positive elements of the army and society. This point remains universally consistent, regardless of era, and across both China and foreign nations.

Apart from these three highly representative records, *The Record* (《要录》) contains many other accounts discussing the superiority and necessity of **feudalized** frontier warlords (藩镇).

For example, Volume 5 records that Tang Zhong (唐重), then in charge of administering the Guanzhong region, told Zhao Gou—who had just ascended the throne—that the most urgent matter for the realm right now was for the emperor to relocate to his region, and the second most urgent matter was to extensively establish frontier warlords.

Volume 21 records the eminent minister Zhang Jun (张浚) writing to Zhao Gou, stating that given the current situation north of the Yangtze River, it was impossible to govern using the bureaucratic system; establishing frontier warlords was absolutely mandatory. At that time, alongside Zhang Jun, 19 others submitted memorials emphasizing the necessity of establishing frontier warlords.

Volume 33 records Chancellor Fan Zongyin (范宗尹) advising Zhao Gou, saying it was true that Emperor Taizu, Zhao Kuangyin, pacified the world's frontier warlords, enabling the bureaucratic state to remain basically stable for 150 years. However, when the Jin troops drove south, the court's inability to cope was precisely the inherent flaw of the bureaucratic state. To survive the current catastrophe, the frontier warlord system should be partially restored; vast regions south of the Yellow River and north of the Yangtze should be subinfeudated (裂土而治), allowing the warlord commanders to defend their respective territories as a defensive screen (屏障) for the court.

Later in the same volume, an edict issued by Zhao Gou himself is recorded. Following the classic nonsense format of Chinese political documents, this edict first affirmed the martial achievements of the Zhou Dynasty's enfeoffment system (封邦建国) in expanding the Huaxia realm, as well as the effectiveness of the Tang Dynasty's frontier warlords in resisting border threats. It then immediately announced that he would grant full autonomy to the anti-Jin armed forces in the contested zone between Song and Jin, allowing them absolute regional authority, stating that as long as they could hold off the Jin people, they would have merit.

But even so, Zhao Gou adamantly refused to grant these regional strongmen hereditary power (世袭权力).

Fan Zongyin and others countered that after years of war, the region north of the Yangtze was already in utter ruins; if the warlords were not permitted hereditary succession, who would fight to the death to defend it?

To this, Zhao Gou replied that it was absolutely impermissible. If just anyone could inherit titles hereditarily, what would be the point of him being a despotic emperor? Furthermore, he knew exactly what he was doing: all he wanted was for them to secure the remaining territory. He had zero expectations for a counter-offensive, and granting them this much authority was already sufficient to hold the line. Ultimately, he steadfastly refused to permit hereditary succession.

The most wryly amusing record is found in Volume 61, containing a rather lengthy memorial submitted to Zhao Gou by a commoner from Huangzhou named Wu Shen (吴伸).

Right from the start, Wu Shen condemned Zhao Gou's behavior of seeking only temporary, ignoble peace (苟求偏安) instead of aspiring to recover the lost territories and exact revenge. He pointed out that even seeking temporary peace was impossible, for since antiquity, during periods of North-South division, it had always been the North unifying the South; there was no counter-example. Even the puppet emperor of Qi, Liu Yu, knew to actively prepare for war against the Song. If you,

the orthodox emperor, do absolutely nothing, wouldn't the chances of survival diminish the longer this dragged on?

He also heard that the Jin Dynasty might amass heavy troops to attack Sichuan from Guanzhong. If Sichuan were lost, it would be utterly over. The Southeast was never meant to be an imperial capital; once the upper reaches of the Yangtze were lost, Zhao Gou would swiftly become the next "Marquis of Returning Allegiance" Sun Hao (归命侯孙皓) or "Duke of Changcheng" Chen Shubao (长城公陈叔宝)—notorious monarchs of subjugated southern states.

At the end of the memorial, Wu Shen began worrying on behalf of Emperor Zhao Gou, noting that many regional commanders now possessed actual power identical to frontier warlords. How could an emperor yield military power to outsiders? But then he twisted his argument, clarifying that **although he opposed frontier warlords, he did not oppose feudalism! He merely opposed these frontier warlords being non-imperial vassals of different surnames.**

Therefore, he suggested that enfeoffment (分封) was absolutely necessary, but it should be bestowed upon the royal kinsmen of the Zhao clan. Just like the Zhou Dynasty, using the imperial clan as a defensive screen would ensure long-lasting prosperity.

Reading Wu Shen's memorial, it is hard not to realize that his understanding of history was quite astute for his time, indicating he likely hailed from a landlord class family with relatively good living conditions. However, it is almost certain that Wu himself had absolutely no connections at court. This is obvious because he was entirely ignorant of a widely known fact: the Zhao Song imperial family suffered from severe reproductive difficulties and high infant mortality rates!

Enfeoffing the imperial clan was a non-starter because there was simply no one to enfeoff; even Gaozong (Zhao Gou) himself had no heirs. If imperial kinsmen had to be enfeoffed, they could only find extremely distant branches, which would make them no different from outsiders. Yet even such a low-ranking member of the landlord class, lacking political standing, simultaneously opposed warlords with different surnames while *not* opposing the institution of frontier warlords itself.

The sources of these aforementioned comments—which approved of establishing frontier warlords and acknowledged the distinct superiority of **feudalized** frontier warlords in resisting the Jin invasion—were incredibly diverse. They ranged from small landlords at the bottom to Emperor Zhao Gou himself at the top; moreover, the officials listed did not belong to a single political faction.

This fully demonstrates that even up to the early 12th century, the superiority of the feudal system was fundamentally not a secret in Chinese society; it was virtually common knowledge among all educated people.

However, to maintain their despotic rule, the rulers would rather sacrifice this superiority to uphold the massive cage that was the bureaucratic system!

The fact is, once the Southern Song and the Jin had reached a basic parity, the despotic monarch of the Southern Song was inevitably going to systematically eliminate the military commanders, whom he viewed as thorns in his eyes and flesh (眼中钉、肉中刺).

In *The Record*, the murder of Yue Fei (岳飞) is recorded in Volume 143. In the records following that event, the image of the frontier warlords as battle-hardened veterans capable of warfare was

swiftly replaced by an image of them being "domineering and lawless" (跋扈不法), laying bare the sheer brutality and hypocrisy of the bureaucratic state.

In Volume 147, Zhao Gou explicitly told Qin Hui that the reason the Tang Dynasty's frontier warlords spiraled out of control was that the court did not cut them down early enough. Therefore, he was determined to comprehensively reclaim military power and, once again, be a "great despotic monarch" (伟大的专制君主).

Therefore, we can state with absolute certainty that China's despotic rulers were perfectly aware that armed forces with **feudal characteristics** (封建特征) possessed stronger combat effectiveness. They knew even better that this very combat effectiveness had the potential to destroy the despotic, centralized bureaucratic system itself.

Consequently, when facing external crises, they would consciously allow feudal elements to develop to a certain extent in order to utilize their military power to maintain their remnant empire. And the moment the external threat rapidly weakened, the court would immediately "slaughter the donkey after the millstone is done turning" (卸磨杀驴).

Meanwhile, China's **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级), under the prolonged suppression of the bureaucratic system, became increasingly debilitated. The fragmentation of land property rights and the social atomization (全社会的原子化) of the entire society made it even more difficult for the landlord class to bear military obligations.

Thus, we witness a ludicrous reality: even after the transition between the two Song dynasties, when China's despotic rulers faced overwhelmingly powerful external threats, they still thought of utilizing **feudalized** armed forces.

For example, while Emperor Xuanzong of Jin was deciding to flee south to Kaifeng, he enfeoffed nine **feudal lords** as dukes in the already out-of-control Hebei region, attempting to rely on them to block the aggressive spearhead of the Mongol invasion. In the precarious final years of the Ming Dynasty, there was no shortage of officials who consistently advocated for the early organization of local militias. Even the Hongguang regime—regarded as corrupt and incompetent to the extreme—attempted before its demise to grant greater autonomy to the Jiangbei military garrisons to emulate the precedent of the Southern Song.

However, by this time, China had deviated from the path of **feudalization** for far too long. It had become extremely difficult for people to even imagine the organizational form of a **feudal society**. The increasingly consolidated bureaucratic society made it increasingly impossible to establish a **superstructure** (上层建筑) based on a feudal economy.

Even if the landlord class was bestowed with righteous titles and legitimacy (大义名分), they lacked the capacity to establish a reliable local administrative system in a short time and exert any military function.

Not to mention that, having entered the **restoration-bureaucratic society** for so long, people had long grown accustomed to the court's treacherous practice of "*hiding the bow once the birds are shot, and boiling the hound once the hares are caught*" (鸟尽弓藏, 兔死狗烹). Who would be foolish enough to genuinely believe the court possessed any credibility?

For the local separatist warlords, their expectation of the court's credibility was not necessarily higher than their expectation of the Manchus who were **Entering the Pass** (入关). This was particularly evident at the end of the Ming Dynasty.

Therefore, since the Song Dynasty, the despotic courts' attempts to temporarily release some feudal elements to seek a momentary, ignoble peace when left helpless against external military threats have all ended in utter failure.

Finally, what I especially want to say is this: when a contemporary Chinese citizen reconsiders the historical event of the Jingkang Incident, he must never forget that **the true humiliation lies in the fact that the commoners of the Song Dynasty (naturally including the landlord class) were utterly unable to master their own destiny under the oppression of emperors and bureaucrats—a gang of robbers, bandits, thieves, and fraudsters!**

When one slave-owner viciously beats another slave-owner and plunders his slaves, the true humiliation for the slave lies in the very fact of *being a slave*, not in being plundered as a slave to the other side. The latter is the humiliation of the slave-owner, and belongs in no way to the slave.

The humiliation of Jingkang has yet to be washed away! (靖康耻，犹未雪！)

3, 中国统治者很清楚封建制度在军事上的优越性

第三个方面，封建制度在军事上优于复辟官僚制度压根就不是现代人才意识到的结论，事实是在官僚复辟时期即使是专制君主和高级官僚都不得不承认这一点。如果我们注意到两宋之交最为重要的一些历史文献，《三朝北盟会编》以及《建炎以来系年要录》，就不难发现有关当时人承认封建化藩镇在面对新兴少数民族政权压力时显著的优越性。下面列举一些从内容上看极为有趣的历史片段，人们可以很容易从中看出即使到公元 12 世纪初中国的统治者和高级知识分子对于“天下成败”依然有着何等清晰的认识。第一份记录是靖康之变刚刚发生时（靖康二年二月）御史中丞秦桧给金朝都元帅府的上书，见于《要录》的卷二以及《会编》的卷八十，其中有一段是这么说的：

大金自去岁问罪中原，入境征战已逾岁矣。然所攻必克者无他，以大金久习兵革，中国承平百年，士卒罕练将帅未得其人也。自古中国地土甲兵之威四邻无有，将相英雄世不乏才。使异日士卒精练，若唐藩镇之兵，将相得人，若唐代肅之臣。大金之於中国能必其胜哉！

秦桧这段对金朝统治者劝谏的目的核心就在两点，不要灭宋（而立张邦昌），不要诛戮赵宋宗室，这作为亡国之臣的立场本身是非常正常的。真正让这份文件具有相当“历史意义”的是秦桧给出的惊人的论点，他在最初强调赵宋天命未绝之后，极为隐晦地指出了关键性的利益问题所在：“你们金人之所以能够长驱直入取得如此之大的战果，并非因为你们强到不可战胜，而是宋朝本身极度衰弱所致。（自五代之后，宋朝建立为了压制国内一切可能的不确定因素建立了空前庞大的官僚体制，皇帝视自己的利益高过了国家的利益，担心自己的军队和将领超过了担心异族的军队和将领）因此整个国家的武装力量不堪一击。（今天金朝如果非要尽诛赵氏，那么反而为天下除去一个独夫）像唐代那样的封建化藩镇就会接踵而起。凭借中国的人口和经济规模，到那个时候你们金人自忖还能战而胜之吗？不如保留宋朝的社稷，仍然让赵氏做专制君主，（这样赵宋官家为了一姓私利首先警惕自己的将领和百姓，替金人消弭了这一真正的危险）对于你们金朝统治者也好，赵宋皇室也罢都是有利的。”

秦桧的这段上书充分反映了他作为中国特有的“官僚主义政治家”的惊人眼光，其对于天下的形势以及各方的利益诉求即使在靖康之变刚刚发生的时候就已经了如指掌了。秦桧清楚地意识到封建化藩镇在应对金朝入侵这样的历史事件中具有宋代官僚体制无可比拟的优越性，但是宋帝国的专制君主出于对残唐五代的历史记忆和维护专制统治的需要，对于这些卧榻之侧的威胁必然感到如坐针毡。当宋朝能够与金朝取得基本均势时，皇帝对藩镇的恐惧显然会超过对于那些用土地、钱财和人民就可以打发的异族。因此秦桧在靖康之变之初就敏锐地指出，从长远来看两国进行和议对于双方统治者都有利。然而迅速崛起的金朝人不可能这么快就理解中国的政治也不可能就如此快的刹住征服的战车，南宋为了迫使金人回到谈判桌上，只能效仿唐时藩镇，利用一定程度封建化的军事统帅以武力达成均势并尽快实现和议。这

样一来就可以集中精力软硬兼施地夺取这些将帅的兵权，对于其中颇有战功和威望且不甚顺从者，“莫须有”罪名也可杀之。两宋之交中国大地所展现的历史画卷，为后人清晰地展现了复辟官僚国家的极端反动性以及其推行反动政策的主观性。

第二份记录是赵构刚刚称帝一个月的建炎元年6月2日（与靖康二年是同一年，即公元1127年）当时的宰相李纲给赵构的一次上书，见于《要录》卷六，《会编》卷一百零五。这份奏书的意思非常直白，就是指出要坚决公开地放弃议和，明确要继续与金朝的战争并首先加强防备，尔后图谋复仇，眼下国家的一切事务应该围绕对金战争展开。在这封奏书中李纲明确指出藩镇的在眼下是非常有用且必要的。

为今之计，莫若一切罢和议，専务自守之策，建藩镇于要害之地，置帅府于大河及江淮之南，修城壁，治器械，教水军，习车战，使其进无抄掠之得，退有邀击之患，则虽有出没，必不敢深入，三数年间，军政益修，甲车咸备，然后大举以讨之，报不共戴天之仇，雪振古所无之耻，彼知中国自强如此，岂徒不敢肆横，而二圣有可安之理矣！

在这一段论述中人们可以清晰地看到李纲对于藩镇的军事作用有相当的认知，他特别指出反正可以修建大量封建城堡并自行武装军队。一旦金军发动进攻则城堡附近的百姓可以撤入其中，物资也可以被转移并保护（这就和中世纪的欧洲差不多了），金军想要攻克这样的城堡非常困难，所以即使进兵也很难掠夺到多少物资。但是如果金军想要轻易撤走，那么他就要想方设法避免城堡里的军队进行追击，因此金军虽然还是会出没在边境上，却很难大幅深入。这种认识很可能反映了金军南侵唤起了当时人们对于十六国时期北方汉族豪强曾经广泛修建的坞堡的历史记忆。而宋高宗对于这份上奏的反应是“上大喜，付中书省遵守。”，由此可见，即使是赵构本人对于李纲的说法也没有什么异议。

第三份文件是建炎三年八月兵部尚书谢克家的一次进言，见于《要录》卷二十七，他说的话很短，但是几乎句句直击要害。谢克家的这次进言完全可以称得上是隋唐至今中国政论的最高水准。

兵部尚书谢克家言，今日官冗，外方尤甚，请悉罢之，以纾民力。又言：「官军单寡，而郡县皆有土豪，宜令自相推择，有智勇者各守其地，郡县有阙官处，乞许郡守自辟。吏铨无碍，则付以告身。若其徇私，则监司、御史得以纠之。今京东、西及江、淮悉为榛莽，难用常法，宜建藩镇，文武并授，令得便宜从事，财赋亦听自用。如捍御有功，则许世袭」。

以上短短四行话中竟然表达了五个观点。第一，虽然说宋帝国的冗官现象本身就是维护专制皇权巩固复辟官僚制度的手段，但是现在金兵肆虐中国赵宋官家的皇位本就不稳你还这么做就很离谱了。特别是地方上，臃肿的官僚体制根本缺乏有效的回应还凭空消耗了地方的财力，根本不足以应对军事威胁，建议应撤尽撤，先别再折腾老百姓。第二，地方上的有实力的地主阶级能够成为承担军事义务抵抗金兵的中流砥柱，眼下这种情况就应该重用他们，不要管合不合乎官僚体制的程序，先把大义名分给下去再说。第三，虽然太宗皇帝赵光义坚决要把全国官员的任免权都收归中央，但是现在对付金人是首务，就不要再搞那套相互制衡互拖后腿的诡计了。眼下最好把人事权也下放，这样扩大了地方的积极性，增强其行动力。地方举荐的官员差不多就直接承认，就算出什么问题让御史弹劾警告一下就得了。第四，现在宋金之间上千公里的交战区上一片混乱，豪杰并起，说什么重建官僚制度简直是扯淡。我们现在应该赶紧设置藩镇争取那些地方武装，让文臣和武将都出现在藩镇的框架内，扩大他们自行决断的权力。同时不再从藩镇征税，让他们用军事义务去替代。第五，只要这些藩镇抵抗金军有功，不要想着再用流官把人家拿掉，直接允许世袭封王封公。所以人们可以很明显地从谢克家的话中感觉到，尽管中华帝国已经进入了复辟官僚时期，但是直到两宋之交的时候知识分子仍然对封建化有很深的了解，他们很清楚封建社会本来应该有什么特征，甚至在心里十分明白封建制度比起复辟官僚制度有多大的优越性。但是相互依存的君主专制和官僚制度已经如此稳固，面对金兵南侵这样的重大威胁的时候朝廷虽然会允许一些封建化因素重新出现，但是一旦威胁消失，国家便不可避免地回到了通向末日的老路上去。

其实明智的人都能意识到像这样异常的官僚制度主要是想对付谁根本不是秘密，例如苏联在1942年造成纳粹德国进攻最为艰难的时期废除了政委的最终决定权，从此政工干部在军队中的权力受到限制，越来越弱化。老奸巨猾的官僚统治者永远不会忘记他们的刺刀指向自己的人民，而不是为了抵抗什么外国侵略者，一旦外部的威胁变得过大之后他们自己也会消除一些官僚制度来释放军队和社会的积极因素，这一点无论何时不分中外都是一致的。

除了这三处非常有代表性的记载以外，《要录》中论述封建化藩镇优越性和必要性的记载还有很多。例如卷五中记载当时负责管理关中地区的唐重给刚刚称帝的赵构说，现在天下之事最紧急的就是你赶紧迁到我这，第二急的就是需要广泛设置藩镇。卷二十一中记载名臣张浚书给赵构说现在江北的情况如果

想用官僚制管理不可能，非得设置成藩镇不可，当时与张浚一样上疏强调设置藩镇必要性的还有 19 人。卷三十三中记载宰相范宗尹对赵构进言说，当年太祖皇帝赵匡胤削平了天下藩镇让官僚国家基本稳定了 150 年，这是不假，但是等到金兵南下的时候朝廷对此难以应对就是官僚国家的弊端。现在要想应对眼下的大难，就应该部分的恢复藩镇，在黄河以南长江以北的广大区域裂土而治让藩帅各守其土作为朝廷的屏障。在同一卷靠后的位置记载了赵构自己下的诏书，这篇诏书依照中国政治文献的经典废话格式先肯定了周朝封邦建国扩大诸夏的武功以及唐代藩镇抵御边患的有效，紧接着宣布自己将给予宋金拉锯地带的抗金武装充分的自主权令其专制一方只要能抵挡金人就是有功。但是即使如此赵构还是不愿意给予地方实权派世袭权力，范宗尹等人反驳说现在江北战乱数年已经残破成那个样子，如果还不允许藩帅世袭的话谁还会出死力防守？对此赵构表示绝对不行，要是什么人都能世袭那我这个专制皇帝还当个什么。况且自己心里有数，我要的是他们只要把剩下的疆域保住就行了，又不指望反攻，给这么多权限就已经足矣守住了，最终还是坚持不许世袭。

而最为令人哭笑不得的一段记载则是卷六十一中黄州布衣吴伸给赵构的上书，而且篇幅不小。吴伸上来就谴责了赵构不思收复故土报仇雪恨只求偏安的行为，并且指出即使想要偏安也是不可能的，因为自古以来南北并立从来都是北方统一南方，没有反过来的例子。伪齐皇帝刘豫都知道积极准备与宋朝的战争，而你一个正统皇帝居然毫无作为那岂不是时间越拖越没戏。又听说金朝可能要集结重兵从关中进攻四川，四川要是丢了那就更完蛋，东南本非帝王之都，一旦长江上游一失那很快就会成为下一个归命侯孙皓，长城公陈叔宝。吴伸在最后又为皇帝赵构担忧起来，说是现在那么多节帅已经实同藩镇，哪有皇帝把兵权让给外人的呢？但是他笔锋一转表明他虽然反对藩镇但是并不反对封建，他只是反对这些藩镇属于非皇族的异姓诸侯罢了。所以他建议必须分封，但是应该分封的是赵氏的宗亲，就像周朝一样把宗室作为藩屏，这样就能昌盛很久。如果我们读完吴伸的上书就很难不意识到他对于历史的了解在当时看来已经颇为精当，这足以显示他大概出身于生活条件还不错的地主阶级家庭，不过吴本人十有八九是在朝中没有任何关系的。这是因为他居然不知道赵宋皇室生育困难和夭折率高这么众所周知的特点，分封宗室根本就是没人可封，即使是高宗赵构本人也没有任何子嗣。就算真的要分封宗室那就只能找很远的远支，跟外姓也就没有什么区别了。可就是这样一个缺乏政治地位的下层地主阶级成员，同样也是反对异姓藩镇不反对藩镇。

以上我所列举的这些赞同设置藩镇，承认封建化藩镇在抵御金朝入侵时具有显著优越性的言论来源可谓复杂，下至小地主，上至皇帝赵构本人，至于所列举的这些官员也并非出自一派。这充分表明，即使到公元 12 世纪初封建制度的优越性在中国社会根本不是什么秘密，简直是所有有文化的人众所周知的事，但是统治者为了自己的专制统治宁可牺牲掉这样的优越性也要维护官僚制度这个大囚笼。事实就是当南宋和金已经基本达成均势的时候，南宋的专制君主势必就要把作为眼中钉、肉中刺的军事统帅们相继拔除。《要录》中岳飞被杀之事记录在第一百四十三卷中，在那以后的记录中藩镇的“跋扈不法”的形象取代了其能征惯战的形象，官僚国家的凶残虚伪暴露无遗。在第一百四十七卷，赵构明确对秦桧表示唐代藩镇之所以失控就是因为朝廷没有早早把他们削掉，所以自己现在就要彻底收回兵权重新做一个伟大的专制君主。

因此我们可以非常确定地说，中国的专制统治者非常清楚具有封建色彩的军事武装具有更强的战斗力，他们更知道这种战斗力有可能会毁灭专制主义中央集权官僚制度自身。因此他们在面临外部危机时会有意识地放任封建因素取得一定的发展以利用其军事力量维持残余的江山，一旦外部威胁迅速削弱朝廷就会立马卸磨杀驴。而中国的封建地主阶级在长期被官僚制度的压制下变得越来越衰弱，土地产权的分散和全社会的原子化使得地主阶级更加难以承担军事义务。于是我们看到的一个可笑的事实是，哪怕在两宋之交以后，中国的专制统治者在面临过于强大的外部威胁时虽然还是会想着利用封建化武装，例如金宣宗在决定南逃开封的同时在已经失控的河北地区册封了九个封建领主为公爵，试图依靠他们来阻挡蒙古的侵略兵锋。明王朝在风雨飘摇的最后几年里，同样不乏官员一直主张早早组织地方团练，即使是被视为腐败无能至极的弘光政权，在临死之前也试着给予江北军镇更大自主权以效南宋故事。然而此时中国偏离封建化道路已经太久太久，人们已经很难想象封建社会的组织形式，越来越巩固的官僚社会使得基于封建经济的上层建筑变得越来越不可能建立起来。地主阶级即使被给予了大义名分，也没有能力在短时间内建立起可靠的地方行政体制并且在军事上发挥作用了。更不要说进入官僚复辟社会这么久以来，人们早就见惯了朝廷“鸟尽弓藏，兔死狗烹”的事，谁会傻乎乎的真的相信朝廷有信誉一般。对于地方的割据军阀来说，他们对朝廷信誉的期望值未必比得对上入关的满人，这一点在明朝末年尤为明

显。因此自宋朝之后，专制朝廷在面对外部军事威胁束手无策时试图暂时释放一些封建因素以求苟安的尝试都失败了。最后我尤其想说的是，一个当代的中国公民再次考虑起靖康之变这个历史事件的时候，他绝不应该忘记真正的耻辱在于宋朝的百姓（当然也包括地主阶级）在皇帝和官僚这群强盗，匪徒，窃贼和诈骗犯的压迫下无法主宰自己的命运。一个奴隶主狠狠地殴打了另一个奴隶主并掠夺了其奴隶，奴隶真正的耻辱在于自己身为奴隶的这个事实，而不在于作为奴隶被掠夺到另外一方，后者是奴隶主的耻辱而不属于奴隶。

靖康耻，犹未雪！